Committee Secretary

Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters

PO Box 6021, Parliament House,

CANBERRA ACT 2600

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RE: Draft Submission to the Federal Parliament's Standing Committee on Electoral Matters, from the Blue Mountains Unions Council Inc (BMUC) Concerning the activities of the Plymouth Brethren during the 2025 Federal Election.

Dear Committee Secretary,

The Blue Mountains Union Council Inc (known as the BMUC) unanimously agreed at a recent meeting on 6th August 2025 to correspond with the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters in relation to concerns about the activities of the Plymouth Brethren at the 2025 Federal Election.

Many of our members observed prior to and during the last Federal election the Plymouth Brethren (formerly known as the Exclusive Brethren) played a prominent role inundating polling stations in the seat of Macquarie and other selected electorates. We saw many Brethren members wearing blue t-shirts distributing [redacted] party leaflets and urging people to vote for the [redacted] candidate. It was noted that it was not just the large numbers of the Brethren members but their sometimes-aggressive behaviour towards members of rival political parties that was noticeable and disturbing to the voting public.

We wish to draw the Committee members attention to the fact that during the election, as well as afterwards, the Plymouth Brethren claimed their church did not campaign, support or donate to any political party. We understand that they generally encourage their members to not participate or vote in elections. It was therefore surprising that this organisation mobilised so many of its members into action prior to, and during the 2025 Federal election.

We learnt from the Sun Herald investigation (8th June, 2025) that the leader of this organisation, [redacted] issued a rallying call to his congregation in April 2025 on their Brethren app called the Global Media stream, to get involved 'Pray and take action' to ' Make Australia Smile Again' by manning polling booths and handing out [redacted] how to vote material.

In the Sun Herald's investigation into the Brethren's involvement, it highlighted their large presence in the marginal seats of Gilmore, Bennelong as well as other seats including our own seat of Macquarie. From their investigation we learnt that Brethren members were flown into remote parts of central Australia to campaign. This raises the issue of third-party disclosure, as other organisations are expected to register with the electoral commission as a significant third party, such as the Australian Council of Trade Unions.

Another source (Sydney Morning Herald, May 1st, 2025) stated the *'.... the church has increased efforts to disguise from the public that its members are volunteering in the* [redacted] *Party's election campaign and has urged followers to turn up en masse on election day. In a secret recording, obtained by this*

blue mountains unions & community BMUC inc

[redacted]

masthead, of a post campaign briefing call, a senior Brethren member instructed those working as volunteers to avoid answering questions about their religious affiliations by pretending not to know what the questioner was talking about'.

The Sun Herald reported that Joo-Cheong-Tham, a professor at Melbourne Law School and director of the Centre for Public Integrity called for an enquiry into the Plymouth Brethren's involvement in the 2025 Federal election. He was quoted as saying: …*'It's critical that there is transparency in relation to third party expenditure'* he added *'that (the) Brethren's effort appeared highly co-ordinated but not necessarily funded by a single entity, which exposes a "regulatory gap" that deserves scrutiny'.*

The BMUC urges the Federal Standing Committee into Electoral Matters to examine the role, conduct and the transparency of the Plymouth Brethren in the 2025 Federal election.

Yours Sincerely,

[redacted]

Secretary, Blue Mountains Union Council Inc

CC: Committee Chair, Jerome Laxale MP, PO Box 6022, House of Representatives, Parliament House, Canberra, ACT 2600

CC: Susan Templeman MP, PO Box 6022, House of Representatives, Parliament House, CANBERRA ACT 2600